

Pre-Listing Prep & Styling Checklist — New South Wales

Getting your property market-ready without overspending on the wrong things.

Correct as at July 2026. General information only, not legal, financial or valuation advice.

Section 1 — Before You Spend Anything

- ☐ [] **Start your Contract of Sale early.** Since NSW requires the vendor to prepare the Contract of Sale (including the s10.7 planning certificate) before the property is listed, engage your solicitor or conveyancer as one of your very first steps — not something to organise after styling is underway.
- ☐ [] **Get a professional appraisal from 2-3 agents** before deciding your preparation budget.
- ☐ [] **Decide: renovate, style, or sell as-is?** Major renovations rarely return their cost dollar-for-dollar in a short pre-sale timeframe; targeted, lower-cost improvements often deliver a better return.

Section 2 — High-Return, Low-Cost Improvements

- ☐ [] **Declutter aggressively** — consistently the highest-return, lowest-cost step.
- ☐ [] **Deep clean throughout**, including often-overlooked areas.
- ☐ [] **Fix small, visible defects** — leaking taps, cracked tiles, chipped paint.
- ☐ [] **Freshen paint in neutral tones** where walls are marked or dated.
- ☐ [] **Improve street appeal** — especially important in competitive Sydney markets where first impressions from listing photos drive inspection numbers.

Section 3 — Styling Decisions

- ☐ [] **Consider professional staging for vacant properties** — empty rooms often photograph poorly and are harder for buyers to size up mentally.
- ☐ [] **For occupied properties, focus on de-personalising** rather than full staging.
- ☐ [] **Get professional photography and floor plans regardless of styling budget** — not an area to cut costs on.
- ☐ [] **Ask your agent for their honest opinion on styling ROI** for your specific property, rather than assuming more spend always helps.

Section 4 — Compliance Items to Check Before Listing

- ☐ [] **Check smoke alarm compliance** — well-maintained smoke alarms avoid last-minute issues and signal a well-kept property.
- ☐ [] **Gather your Home Building Compensation Fund certificate** if the property has had building work over \$20,000 in the past 6 years.
- ☐ [] **If in a strata scheme, gather your strata records** — recent AGM minutes, financials, and any known disputes or special levies, which buyers' solicitors will request.
- ☐ [] **Confirm your s10.7 planning certificate is current** — request an updated one from council if your existing copy is older, since buyers expect recent information.

Section 5 — Timing Your Campaign

- ☐ [] **Discuss timing with your agent relative to market conditions** — Sydney's spring selling season is traditionally strong, though this varies year to year.
- ☐ [] **Align your preparation timeline with your agent's proposed campaign start** rather than rushing to meet an arbitrary date.
- ☐ [] **Plan your own moving logistics in parallel** — see the separate Pre-Settlement Checklist in this series for settlement-week logistics that apply to you as the seller too.

Quick Reference — Where to Spend, Where to Save

HIGH-RETURN, LOW-COST	OFTEN LOWER-RETURN RELATIVE TO COST
Decluttering	Full kitchen/bathroom renovations
Deep cleaning	High-end fixture upgrades
Minor repairs	Structural changes shortly before sale
Professional photography	Extensive landscaping overhauls
Fresh neutral paint (where needed)	Full furniture replacement for occupied homes

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